Plan 5 · Uttarakhand: Rishikesh to Chandrashila & Auli

Ganga aarti and cafés in Rishikesh, Devprayag confluence, Deoria Tal, a snow trek to Tungnath & Chandrashila (4,000 m), Auli's slopes and Gorson Bugyal, Haridwar. 24 Dec 2026 – 3 Jan 2027

At a glance

Route	Hyderabad → Delhi → Rishikesh 2N → Devprayag → Sari 1N → Chopta/Duggalbitta 2N → Joshimath 2N (Auli) → Haridwar → Delhi → Hyderabad
Snow chances	High: Tungnath–Chandrashila, Auli, Gorson. Medium: Deoria Tal, Chopta. None: Rishikesh, Haridwar
Crowd level	Medium in Rishikesh. Low–medium at Chopta (weekend trekkers). Low at Auli (ropeway shut) and Deoria Tal
Difficulty	Moderate. Chandrashila in snow is a 6–8 h day (about 10 km round trip from Chopta) and needs microspikes and a guide
Temperatures	Rishikesh 7–20 °C · Sari 0–12 °C · Chopta −8 to 3 °C · Auli/Joshimath −6 to 8 °C
Budget (per person, 4 people)	≈ ₹20.1k shoestring (buses + shared jeeps) · ≈ ₹30.3k recommended (one cab for 6 days)

Things that changed recently

Joshimath–Auli ropeway is shut (since Jan 2023 land subsidence). A new line is only at project-report stage. Auli is reached by road (16 km from Joshimath; local jeeps run). Don't pay any 'ropeway ticket' website.

Tungnath temple doors are closed in winter (the deity moves to Makkumath). The trek is open and snow-covered. In winter, stays beyond Duggalbitta are closed and there is no electricity at the higher points.

Rishikesh's old **Laxman Jhula** bridge has been closed for safety since 2022; use Ram Jhula / Janki Setu.

Getting there and back

Hyderabad → Delhi: trains that work for 24 Dec (early morning first)

Train	Boards in Hyderabad	Reaches	Runs	Classes · approx fare / person	Use on 24 Dec?
12723 Telangana SF Exp	Hyderabad Deccan (Nampally) **06:00** · Secunderabad 06:20/06:25	New Delhi ~07:40–08:00 next day (~25.5 h)	Daily	SL ≈ ₹800 · 3A ≈ ₹2,100 · 2A ≈ ₹3,000	**Yes, best early-morning train**
22691 Bengaluru–Nizamuddin Rajdhani	Secunderabad **07:00 arr / 07:10 dep** (10-min halt)	H. Nizamuddin ~05:30 next day (~22 h)	Daily	3A ≈ ₹3,300–4,100 · 2A ≈ ₹4,500–5,500 (flexi fare, meals incl.)	Yes. Fastest morning option
12285 Secunderabad–Nizamuddin Duronto	Secunderabad **12:50**	H. Nizamuddin ~10:40 next day (~22 h)	**Sun & Thu**	AC only · 3A ≈ ₹3,000–3,700 (meals incl.)	**Yes, 24 Dec is a Thursday**
12721 Dakshin SF Exp	Hyderabad Deccan 23:00	H. Nizamuddin ~03:45 on day 3 (~29 h)	Daily	SL ≈ ₹780 · 3A ≈ ₹2,100	Only as a 23-Dec-night fallback (slow)

12723 major halts, in order (check availability to each): Hyderabad Deccan → Secunderabad → Kazipet → Ramagundam → Mancherial → Sirpur Kagaznagar → Balharshah → Chandrapur → Sevagram → Nagpur → Itarsi → Bhopal → Jhansi → Gwalior →

Agra Cantt → New Delhi (about 18 halts in total, ~1,680 km). Confirmed times: HYB 06:00, SC 06:20/06:25, Kazipet 08:03/08:05, Ramagundam 09:28/09:30. Read the other times off NTES or IRCTC on the day.

Waitlisted? Check every halt this way

Step 1. Direct pairs. On IRCTC (or ConfirmTkt / ixigo, same data), search 24 Dec for HYB→NDLS, SC→NDLS, SC→NZM, HYB→NZM in 3A and SL. Note the status for each train: AVAILABLE / RAC / WL number.

Step 2. Every halt (as you asked). If HYB/SC→Delhi shows WL, search the same train from **HYB** to each later halt: Agra Cantt, Gwalior, Jhansi, Bhopal, Itarsi, Nagpur. Seats are split into quotas by distance, so a shorter ticket (e.g. HYB→Agra) can be AVAILABLE while HYB→Delhi is WL. If Agra/Gwalior is available, book it, ride to Agra (about 4 h before Delhi), then take any Agra→Delhi train, Gatimaan/Vande Bharat or bus (2–3.5 h, ₹300–800).

Step 3. Book from the train's origin. For trains that start outside Hyderabad (22691 Rajdhani from Bengaluru, 22705 Humsafar from Tirupati), search **origin→Delhi** (SBC→NZM, TPTY→NZM/Jammu) and set **Boarding Point = Secunderabad**. You pay the full-route fare, but the origin's general quota is often open when the Secunderabad quota is full.

Step 4. Board further up the line. Check the same trains from Kazipet / Ramagundam (table above). You can book HYB→Delhi and board at SC, but you cannot board before the boarding station on your ticket.

Step 5. Split journey. HYB→Nagpur (many trains, short) + Nagpur→Delhi (30+ trains, incl. Rajdhanis from the south). Leave at least 2–3 h for the change.

Step 6. Tatkal on 23 Dec. AC Tatkal opens 10:00 AM, sleeper 11:00 AM. You need an Aadhaar-authenticated IRCTC account (OTP). Log in at 9:55 with saved passenger lists and UPI ready. Premium Tatkal costs more but is easier to get.

Delhi → Hyderabad: trains that get you home by 3 Jan

Train	Leaves	Reaches Hyderabad	Runs	Approx fare (3A)	Fits 'home by 3 Jan'?
12724 Telangana SF Exp	New Delhi **16:00**	Hyderabad Deccan ~17:10 next day	Daily	≈ ₹2,100 (SL ≈ ₹800)	**Leave 2 Jan → home 3 Jan evening**
22692 Nizamuddin–Bengaluru Rajdhani	H. Nizamuddin late evening (≈20:30–21:00, verify)	Secunderabad 17:10 arr / 17:25 dep next day	Daily	≈ ₹3,300–4,100	**Leave 2 Jan → home 3 Jan 17:10**
12286 Nizamuddin–Secunderabad Duronto	H. Nizamuddin 15:55	Secunderabad ~14:35 next day	Mon & Fri	≈ ₹3,000–3,700	Leave 1 Jan (Fri) → home 2 Jan
12722 Dakshin SF Exp	H. Nizamuddin 22:50	Hyderabad Deccan ~03:50 on day 3	Daily	≈ ₹2,100	Leave 1 Jan night → home 3 Jan 04:00

Delhi ↔ Rishikesh / Haridwar and the hill loop

Leg	Option	Time	Approx cost
Delhi → Rishikesh (25 Dec)	UTC / private Volvo from ISBT Kashmere Gate (frequent through the day)	6–7 h	₹500–900 pp
Alt: Delhi → Dehradun / Haridwar by train	Delhi–Dehradun Vande Bharat / Shatabdi / Jan Shatabdi (VB CC ≈ ₹1,065 at launch; the morning Shatabdi leaves too early for a 07:40 arrival). Check IRCTC for 25 Dec afternoon chair cars	4.5–5 h	₹600–1,100
Rishikesh → Ukhimath (budget)	GMOU / Uttarakhand Roadways bus from Rishikesh bus stand ~05:00–07:00, then shared jeep to Sari	8–9 h	≈ ₹400–500
Hill loop by cab (recommended)	Dzire/Ertiga/Bolero with driver 27 Dec – 1 Jan: Rishikesh → Sari → Chopta → Joshimath/Auli → Haridwar	6 days	≈ ₹3,500–4,000/day + ₹300 driver night + tolls ≈ ₹24–25k per car
Haridwar → Delhi (1 Jan night)	Overnight train (e.g. Mussoorie Exp-type departures ~22:00–23:30; verify) or UTC Volvo	6–7 h	₹450–800

Flights from Hyderabad (to save 1–2 days)

Route (non-stop)	Airlines	Flight time	Typical Dec–Jan one-way fare*	Useful for
Hyderabad ↔ Delhi	IndiGo, Air India, Akasa, SpiceJet (many daily)	~2 h 10 m	₹6,000–9,000 (24 Dec / 2 Jan can touch ₹10–12k)	Plans 1, 2, 3, 5
Hyderabad ↔ Dehradun	IndiGo (≈10 flights/week, ~10:25 dep on some days)	~2 h 25 m	₹5,000–9,000	Plan 5

*Snapshot ranges from MakeMyTrip, Goibibo, Skyscanner, HappyFares and ixigo pages seen in Nov 2026, not live quotes. IndiGo cabin bag: 7 kg; check-in 15 kg on most fares. Winter jackets count, so wear the heaviest layers on the plane. Book within the next 1–2 weeks: Christmas/New Year fares on these routes usually climb steadily.

Faster by air

Fly Hyderabad → Dehradun (IndiGo direct, about 10 flights a week; ₹5–9k) on 24 Dec and taxi to Rishikesh (~1 h). You gain a full day: add Kunjapuri sunrise + Neer Garh falls, or a night in Khirsu/Lansdowne (offbeat) on the way back.

Day-by-day itinerary

Day 1 · Thu 24 Dec · Hyderabad → on the train

• **06:00 12723 Telangana Express** (or 07:10 22691 Rajdhani from Secunderabad).

Stay: Train | **Day spend (per person):** ₹300 food

Day 2 · Fri 25 Dec · Delhi → Rishikesh · Ganga aarti

• Metro to Kashmere Gate → Volvo to Rishikesh (~09:00 → ~16:00).

• Evening **Triveni Ghat** or **Parmarth Niketan** Ganga aarti (around sunset, ~17:30 in winter).

Stay: Tapovan / Laxman Jhula-side hostel (dorm ₹400–800) or guesthouse (₹1,200–2,000 per room) | **Day spend (per person):** ₹700 bus + ₹600 food

Day 3 · Sat 26 Dec · Rishikesh by scooty

• Rent a scooty (₹500–700 + ₹1,500 deposit). **Beatles Ashram (Chaurasi Kutia)**, Ram Jhula, Janki Setu, Parmarth & Swarg Ashram ghats.

• **Neer Garh waterfall** (short trek, offbeat-ish). Optional river rafting from Shivpuri (16 km, ₹600–1,000). The water is cold but rafts do run.

• Cafés on the Tapovan side, sunset at Beatles Ashram.

Stay: Rishikesh | **Day spend (per person):** ₹350 scooty share + ₹200 fuel + ₹700 rafting (optional) + ₹600 food

Day 4 · Sun 27 Dec · Rishikesh → Devprayag → Rudraprayag → Sari

• Leave 06:30. **Devprayag**: Alaknanda meets Bhagirathi and the Ganga begins. Short walk down to the sangam.

• Optional quick stops: Dhari Devi temple (Srinagar Garhwal), Rudraprayag confluence. Then Ukhimath → **Sari village** (~2,000 m), 7–8 h total.

Stay: Sari homestay (₹1,000–1,800 per room, meals ₹250–350) | **Day spend (per person):** ₹1,035 cab share + ₹600 food

Day 5 · Mon 28 Dec · Deoria Tal → Chopta / Duggalbitta

• Early trek to **Deoria Tal** (2.5–3 km, 1.5 h up): mirror view of Chaukhamba. Ice on the edges in late Dec. Small entry/eco fee.

• Descend, drive to **Duggalbitta / Chopta** (25 km). Rent microspikes + gaiters for tomorrow (₹150–250/day).

• Book your Tungnath guide tonight (₹1,500–2,000 per group).

Stay: Duggalbitta camp / lodge with meals (₹1,000–1,500 pp) | **Day spend (per person):** ₹1,035 cab share + ₹250 rentals

Day 6 · Tue 29 Dec · Tungnath (3,680 m) + Chandrashila summit (4,000 m) in snow

• Start 06:30 from Chopta. 3.5 km to **Tungnath** (world's highest Shiva temple; doors shut in winter) + 1.5 km steep to **Chandrashila**: 360° view of Nanda Devi, Trishul, Chaukhamba, Kedar peaks.

• Turn-around time 12:30 whatever happens. Back by 15:00–16:00. Hot Maggi + chai at Chopta.

Stay: Duggalbitta (or drop to Ukhimath) | **Day spend (per person):** ₹450 guide share + ₹1,200 camp + ₹300 food

Day 7 · Wed 30 Dec · Ukhimath → the five prayags → Joshimath

• **Omkareshwar temple, Ukhimath**, the winter seat of Kedarnath (puja happens here in winter).

• Drive via Rudraprayag → Karnaprayag → Nandprayag → Chamoli → **Joshimath** (6–7 h). If the Chopta–Mandal–Gopeshwar road is open, it's shorter.

• Evening: Narsingh temple (winter seat of Badrinath).

Stay: Joshimath budget hotel (₹1,500–2,500 per room) | **Day spend (per person):** ₹1,035 cab share + ₹700 food

Day 8 · Thu 31 Dec · Auli snow day + Gorson Bugyal · quiet NYE

- Drive up to **Auli** (16 km). Snow slopes, the GMVN ski area (beginner lessons + gear ≈ ₹1,500–2,500/day in season), Auli artificial lake.
- **Gorson Bugyal** (offbeat): 3 km snow walk through oak and rhododendron to a meadow facing Nanda Devi.
- NYE in Joshimath/Auli is low-key: bonfire and dinner at the hotel.

Stay: Joshimath (or Auli GMVN/resorts, ₹3,000+ per room) | **Day spend (per person):** ₹1,035 cab share + ₹300–800 snow activities + ₹800 food

Day 9 · Fri 1 Jan · Joshimath → Haridwar (Har Ki Pauri) → night to Delhi

- Leave by 07:00 (~255 km, 8–9 h). If you reach by 17:30, catch the **Har Ki Pauri** evening aarti in Haridwar.
- Overnight train / Volvo Haridwar → Delhi.

Stay: Train / bus | **Day spend (per person):** ₹1,035 cab share + ₹700 train/bus + ₹600 food

Day 10 · Sat 2 Jan · Delhi → Hyderabad

- **16:00 12724 Telangana Express** (or 22692 Rajdhani late evening).

Stay: Train | **Day spend (per person):** ₹300 room share + ₹600 food

Day 11 · Sun 3 Jan · Home

- Hyderabad ~17:10.

Places: main vs offbeat

Place	Type	Why
Rishikesh (ghats, aarti, Beatles Ashram)	Main	Yoga capital, Ganga, cafés
Neer Garh falls, Kunjapuri (sunrise)	Offbeat	Short hikes near Rishikesh
Devprayag sangam	Semi-offbeat	Where the Ganga officially begins
Sari village + Deoria Tal	Offbeat	Village homestay, mirror lake
Chopta, Tungnath, Chandrashila	Main (trekkers)	Snow trek to 4,000 m with a giant Himalayan panorama
Omkareshwar (Ukhimath), Narsingh (Joshimath)	Offbeat	Winter seats of Kedarnath and Badrinath
Auli slopes	Main	India's best-known ski slopes
Gorson Bugyal	Offbeat	Snow meadow above Auli, few people
Haridwar Har Ki Pauri	Main	Evening aarti

Variants if you prefer

Variant	What changes	Cost impact
Kedarkantha winter trek (classic Dec snow trek, summit ~3,800 m)	Fly HYD → Dehradun 24 Dec; operator pickup Dehradun 25/26 Dec → Sankri → 6D/5N trek → Dehradun 31 Dec/1 Jan; train/flight back	Trek ₹6,000–11,000 (Sankri–Sankri to Dehradun–Dehradun; +5% GST; forest fee ₹150–300). Total ≈ ₹28–34k with one flight
Kumaon: Nainital (main) + Mukteshwar + Binsar / Munsiyari (offbeat)	Delhi → Kathgodam train; Munsiyari is 10–11 h further and gets snow from late Dec	Similar to this plan; more driving
Easy hills: Mussoorie–Landour–Dhanaulti–Kanatal	Base in Mussoorie/Landour, day trips; no trekking	≈ ₹24–28k

Bike / scooty rentals

Where	Rates	Notes
Rishikesh (Tapovan, Laxman Jhula road)	Scooty ₹500–700 · RE ₹1,750–1,900	Deposit ≈ ₹1,500. Many shops restrict use to Rishikesh limits
Dehradun (app rentals)	RE / bikes ₹1,200–2,000	Outstation allowed by some, but snow and ice above 2,500 m (Chopta, Auli) make it unsafe in late Dec
Joshimath	Few shops; ₹800–1,500	Use local jeeps for Auli after snowfall

Winter gear: what to buy, what to rent, and where

Budget for gear: if you own nothing warm, expect ₹4,000–6,500 one-time purchase (thermals, fleece, gloves, cap, socks, sunglasses) + ₹800–1,500 in rentals on the trip (jacket, suit, boots, spikes). The per-plan budgets include only the **rental** part; the purchases you keep are listed separately.

Item	Need	Buy (Decathlon Hyderabad / local)	Rent (where & rate)	Advice
Thermal inner set (top + bottom) ×2	Must	₹800–1,200 per set (local ₹400–600)	Not rented (hygiene)	Buy. Merino/poly, not cotton
Fleece / sweater (mid layer)	Must	₹600–1,200	—	Buy
Padded / down jacket (rated −5 to −10 °C)	Must	₹2,500–5,000	Indiahikes rentals ₹55–80/day (ships to you); trek operators ₹100/day; Manali / Gulmarg shops ₹150–300/day	Rent if you'll never use it again. 10 days ≈ ₹600–1,000
One-piece snow suit	At snow points	—	Solang/Palchan, Kufri, Gulmarg, Tsomgo ₹250–500/day (often with gumboots)	Rent on the spot only on snow days
Gumboots / snow boots	At snow points	—	₹100–200/day (Lachung ~₹100; bundled with suit at Solang ₹400–500)	Rent on the spot
Waterproof trekking shoes	Must (Plans 2, 4, 5)	₹2,000–3,500 (Decathlon MH100/MH500)	Trek operators ₹100–150/day	Buy if you'll trek again
Waterproof gloves + woollen inners	Must	₹300–900 + ₹150	—	Buy
Woollen cap / balaclava / neck gaiter	Must	₹200–400 each	—	Buy
Woollen socks (4 pairs)	Must	₹400–600	—	Buy
UV400 sunglasses	Must on snow	₹300–800	—	Snow glare causes snow-blindness
Microspikes + gaiters	Chopta, Hatu, Jalori, Gulmarg walks	₹1,200–1,800	Chopta/Sari/Sankri ₹150–250/day; gaiters ₹100/day	Rent

Rental points on this route

Point	What you can rent	Rate
Sari / Chopta / Duggalbitta shops	Microspikes, gaiters, trekking poles, gumboots, jackets	₹100–250 per item/day
Auli (GMVN & private ski shops)	Skis, boots, poles, suits; lessons	₹1,500–2,500 per day with instruction
Decathlon Dehradun (buy)	Thermals, fleeces, trek shoes, spikes	Cheaper than buying in the hills
Trek operators (Indiahikes, Trek The Himalayas rentals)	Padded jacket, shoes	₹55–150/day

Budget (per person, 4 people)

Item (per person)	Shoestring	Recommended	Notes
Train Hyderabad → Delhi	₹800	₹2,100	SL vs 3A
Train Delhi → Hyderabad	₹800	₹2,100	
Delhi → Rishikesh bus	₹500	₹800	Ordinary vs Volvo
Haridwar → Delhi overnight	₹450	₹700	
Hill loop transport 27 Dec – 1 Jan	₹3,500	₹6,200	Buses + shared jeeps vs one cab ≈ ₹24.8k ÷ 4
Rishikesh scooty + fuel	₹300	₹350	
Rafting (optional)	₹0	₹700	
Guide for Tungnath–Chandrashila	₹450	₹450	≈ ₹1,800 ÷ 4
Microspikes, gaiters	₹300	₹300	
Auli snow activities	₹300	₹800	
Stays: 2N Rishikesh, 1N Sari, 2N Duggalbitta, 2N Joshimath	₹5,600	₹7,700	Dorms/camps vs rooms (camps include meals)
Food	₹5,000	₹5,500	
Metro, autos, misc	₹400	₹500	
Delhi day room (2 Jan)	₹300	₹300	
Gear rentals (jackets etc.)	₹600	₹800	
Buffer	₹800	₹1,000	
TOTAL per person	**₹20,100**	**₹30,300**	**Fits the ₹25–30k range comfortably. The cheapest of the five if you use buses.**

Bookings to do now

- Return train 2 Jan + Haridwar→Delhi on 1 Jan night, then the onward train for 24 Dec.
- Cab for 27 Dec – 1 Jan from a Rishikesh agency (fix the per-day rate, night halts, and who pays tolls/parking in writing).
- Duggalbitta camp (2 nights) and Joshimath hotel (30–31 Dec). Rishikesh hostels can be booked a week before.

Plan B

- Heavy snow closes Chopta road: stay at Ukhimath/Sari and do Deoria Tal + Kartik Swami (offbeat summit temple, 3 km trek) instead.
- Joshimath–Auli road blocked: Gorson/Auli on foot only if police allow; else go to Khirsu or Lansdowne on the way back.

- Fog delays the train into Delhi on 25 Dec: take a later Volvo, or the overnight Volvo and sleep on the bus.

Carry list

- Original photo ID (Aadhaar/DL) + 2 photocopies + **4 passport photos** (Sikkim permits, J&K checks).
- Power bank (cold drains batteries 2× faster), offline Google Maps, cash ₹5–8k (ATMs fail in snow areas).
- Basic meds: Diamox (only after a doctor's advice) for Nathula / Chandrashila / Zuluk, paracetamol, ORS, cold & cough tabs, band-aids, Vaseline.
- Small daypack, reusable bottle, thermos (hot water in −5 °C mornings), quick-dry towel, plastic bags for wet gear.
- Prepaid SIMs from outside J&K do not work in Kashmir. Carry at least one **postpaid** connection (Plan 3).

Safety & buffers

- Snow and roads change by the hour. Check HP/J&K/Sikkim/Uttarakhand police traffic updates and ask your homestay every evening. National emergency: **112**. HP disaster helpline: **1077**.
- Do not ride rented two-wheelers on fresh snow or black ice (Solang–Atal Tunnel, Narkanda, Gulmarg road, Chopta). Taxis with snow chains are safer after snowfall.
- Book stays for 24 Dec–1 Jan **in advance** (NYE rates in Manali/Shimla/Gulmarg/Darjeeling go 2–3× normal). Prefer free-cancellation rates.
- Keep 3 Jan as a pure buffer: plan to start the last long leg (hills → Delhi/airport) by 1 Jan, because snow and NYE traffic delay buses 3–8 h.
- Chandrashila: don't go without a guide after fresh snow (hidden trail edges). Start early, turn back by 12:30, carry a head-torch.

Sources checked

Reddit could not be searched from this environment (blocked), so traveller reports came from Team-BHP, Tripoto, travel blogs and local news. Live seat availability and live fares could not be fetched (IRCTC needs login and captcha). Use the checklists above to verify.

— Auli ropeway closure since 2023 and DPR status: happyfares Auli guide (Oct 2026), discoverwithdheeraj, Pioneer Edge, The Week
— Chopta–Tungnath–Chandrashila winter conditions & package costs: Indiahikes Chopta guide, Trek The Himalayas, himalayashelter, trekupindia, tourmyholiday
— Kedarkantha 2026 prices: Adventure Club Pune, Trek The Himalayas, Trek Hievers, Himalayan Hikers, TrekGo cost guide (Aug 2026), discoverwithdheeraj
— Uttarakhand offbeat winter (Munsiyari, Chakrata, Khirsu, Harsil, Kanatal): explurger, Outlook Traveller, StayVista, India TV (Dec 2025)
— Delhi–Dehradun Vande Bharat fares/timings: WION, Zee News, NativePlanet (launch 2023; verify current)
— Rishikesh rentals: Thrillophilia, Onn Bikes tariff; Dehradun/hill rentals: bikewalebhaiya
— HYD–DED flights: flightconnections, Skyscanner, HappyFares, tourmyindia (IndiGo direct)